

» RUDRANKKSH PATIL, 19
AIR RIFLE SHOOTING

It was as a lad of 12 in 2016 that Rudrankksh Patil set foot in a shooting range for the first time. His father, Balasaheb Patil, was posted as Deputy Commissioner of Police at Thane when he was invited for the inaugural ceremony of the Dronacharya Shooting Range. The coach, Snehal Kadam, asked Rudrankksh's parents if he would be keen to take up shooting. Father Balasaheb and mother Himangini, a Maharashtra transport department officer, said their son had never shown any inclination towards shooting and was instead keen on football.

Nonetheless, Rudrankksh was given an open sight air rifle, the most rudimentary weapon to begin with in his sport, the 10-metre air rifle event. Initially, he found the pauses and slow pace of the sport a put-off and wanted to return to soccer, but something made him persist. It paid off. In 2016, Rudrankksh won a medal in the district-level competition in Thane, his first recognition and also went on to win a medal at the school-level nationals in Indore. "From an early age, he was well-built and we thought he would be able to handle the weight of the rifle," says Balasaheb. Rudrankksh then moved to the much more competitive peep sight event and continued his medal haul at state and national competitions. The year 2019 marked a turning point—the Patils decided that Rudrankksh would pursue a full-time career in the sport if he won at a shooting Grand Prix in Europe the same year. Rudrankksh did. In 2022, he proved his mettle at the Cairo World Championship, winning gold and secur-



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» ADITI GOPICHAND SWAMI, 17
COMPOUND ARCHERY

At the start of 2021, Aditi Swami, then all of 15, followed her archery coach Pravin Sawant's instructions and put down four goals on the wall of her home in Satara, Maharashtra. Little did she imagine in 2023, in her first year playing as a senior, that she would accomplish two of them: winning the youth world championship in July and then becoming the senior world champion in August. It was the first time that an archer had won both categories in the same year. Third on that list for Aditi is the Asian Games gold.

Eight years ago, Aditi had little idea about archery when her father, Gopichand, a math teacher, took her to the Shahu Stadium in Satara so she could pick up a sport. There was cricket, volleyball and others, but what caught Aditi's eye was one unfolding in the corner—Sawant tutoring kids with a wooden bow and arrow. "Archery was easy to follow. The more focused you are, the more you'll excel," she says. "I tried it for 15 days and my interest only grew." Aditi currently hones her skills at Sawant's Drushti Archery Academy.

Archery is an expensive pursuit and Gopichand initially took a loan of Rs 10 lakh to buy her a bow. "I come from a middle-class family, so we have to be cautious with expenses," says the youngster. Aditi has proven